

Tests that CAN SAVE YOUR LIFE

Get a clean bill of health with these vital drills and stay on top of your game

1 BLOOD PRESSURE

A must-do for stress junkies. High blood pressure, or hypertension, often develops without any symptoms and can lead to heart attack and stroke, if uncontrolled. A simple test measures the maximum pressure in an artery when the heart is beating (systolic) and the least when it's resting (diastolic).



2 BODY MASS INDEX

The weighing scale is passe. Think Body Mass Index (BMI)—your weight in kilograms divided by the square of your height in metres (kg/m^2). A BMI between 18.5 and 25 is normal; overweight if up to 30; obese if up to 40 and beyond 40 you are morbidly obese. Obesity invites cardiovascular diseases, diabetes, arthritis and certain cancers.



3 WAIST CIRCUMFERENCE

If you can't bend over to tie your shoe laces, or your belt needs an extra hole or two, you probably have a serious problem. According to a 2008 study on 359,000 people published in the *New England Journal of Medicine*, those with apple-shaped tummies are more likely to die over the next 10 years, even if they aren't overweight. For men: risky if the waist is at or above 40 inches; for women: if at or above 35.



BONE DENSITY

Sixty-one million Indians have an increased risk of fracture due to low levels of physical activity, smoking, excessive alcohol or caffeine use, low calcium or vitamin D intake and, of course, age. Use the WHO's online FRAX calculation tool to see if you are at risk.

5 BAD CHOLESTEROL

It's a soft, waxy substance that the body needs to work properly. But too much can clog your arteries and lead to heart disease. Some cholesterol is considered "good" (HDL) and some "bad" (LDL). A lipid profile is a battery of blood tests to measure your cholesterol and triglyceride levels. The screening should start at 35 for men and 45 for women.



For healthy people with no symptoms, only a few tests have proven to significantly reduce cancer deaths: pap smears for cervical cancer beginning at age 21; mammograms for breast cancer in women starting at age 40; and tests for colon cancer starting at age 50. Consult your doctor first.

BLOOD SUGAR

Early signs of diabetes can be seemingly harmless: excessive thirst, increased urination, fatigue, weight loss, blurred vision, tingling hands and feet. The Diabetes Association of India recommends blood sugar tests for all individuals over 45.



HEART RISK

Heart attacks have gone up six-fold in urban India in the last four decades. To monitor risk, go for periodic checks from age 35. Diagnostic tests range from recording the electrical activity of the heart, computer imaging to simple needle pricks for blood tests.



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